THE CHARM OFFENSIVE

THE UNION COMMERCE MINISTER STEPS INTO THE HURLY BURLY OF ELECTORAL POLITICS IN HIS MAIDEN ATTEMPT TO WIN A LOK SABHA SEAT

BY RAJ CHENGAPPA & DHAVAL S. KULKARNI IN MUMBAI

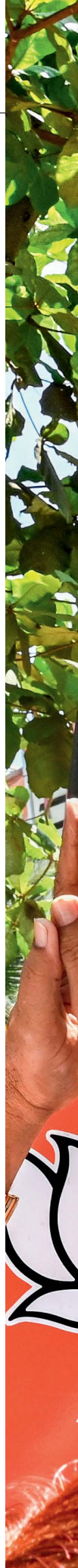
AS THE UNION MINISTER OF COMMERCE, HE IS USED TO WALKING THE RED CARPET. But as Candidate Piyush Goyal, says a partyman with a smile, he is forced to tread a carpet of brown dust and brave Mumbai's sultry heat that leaves his grey Modi jacket drenched in sweat. Goyal himself seems game for the rough and tumble of electoral politics as he greets supporters in a Kandivali bylane in what is his maiden attempt to win a Lok Sabha seat. Though nominated to the Rajya Sabha thrice, he does have some experience at the hustings. When he was a toddler, he points out, his mother, a three-time MLA from Maharashtra, would take him along while campaigning. His first brush with electioneering came when the veteran Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader L.K. Advani asked him to manage his campaign in his first Lok Sabha election in 1989 from New Delhi.

As Goyal sets out, sitting in his rath, an open-roofed saffron-coloured SUV with large cut-outs of Modi emblazoned on its sides, he confesses that he finds the entire experience of campaigning both "exhilarating and elevating" and also unique because of the "feet on the ground" feeling (*see accompanying interview*). He had grown up in the much more storied Sion, an hour's drive away from Kandivali. He recalls that when he was young, Kandivali and much of Mumbai North, the constituency he is contesting from, was full of the stone quarries that supported the maximum city's construction boom. Now in Kandivali, as in neighbouring Borivali, slums have come up higgledy-piggledy, rubbing shoulders with the highrises for the middle and upper middle class, typical of the exponential growth of the Mumbai Metropolitan Region.

THOUGH A THREE-TERM RAJYA SABHA MP, GOYAL IS READY FOR THE CHALLENGES OF ELECTORAL POLITICS AND CRITICISES THE MVA FOR ITS 'DYNASTIC' MINDSET

These are far removed from the sanitised environs of the Don Bosco school in Matunga where Goyal studied, following which he earned a degree in law and studied chartered accountancy at Mumbai University, eventually becoming a successful investment banker. After joining politics in 1989, Goyal gained plenty of party experience helping others campaign and also as the BJP's national treasurer. In 2014, Prime Minister Narendra Modi appointed him a Union minister of state and then elevated him to cabinet rank, where he handled several portfolios including railways, coal, finance and now commerce, textiles and consumers affairs.

As his rath yatra wends it way slowly through the streets of Kandivali, overshadowed by highrises all round, Goyal is all charm, waving cheerily at housewives who peer curiously out of their grilled windows, accepting flowers from an elderly couple that has come out to greet him. He then pauses to talk about the support he is getting from BJP allies, pointing to those carrying Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) flags that have their clock symbol on them and others with the rail engine that represents Raj Thackeray's Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS). Goyal then elaborates



Photograph by MILIND SHELTE